

OXFORD

INTERNATIONAL
AQA EXAMINATIONS

INTERNATIONAL AS LEVEL PSYCHOLOGY

(9685) PS01-Introductory topics in psychology
Report on the examination

January 2023

REPORT ON EXAMINATION: INTERNATIONAL AS LEVEL 9685 INTRODUCTORY TOPICS IN PSYCHOLOGY (PS01) JANUARY 2023

General Feedback

Performance on this exam was comparable to previous series, with students demonstrating similar skills and abilities, as well as similar areas where further development is needed. Overall, students tended to perform much better on questions requiring just AO1 skills but did not often achieve the same level of success on questions requiring AO3 skills. For these questions students tended to identify relevant evaluation issues but did not follow this up with effective elaboration, or alternatively, when elaboration of the issue was provided it tended to be generic and not explicitly relevant to the topic area being evaluated.

There did seem to be an improvement in the ability of students to answer AO2 focused questions, with many more students able to link their answers effectively and consistently to the scenario at hand resulting in higher marks. This seems to have been an area that teachers have been working on with their students and has resulted in more successful responses. A similar focus on the development of AO3 skills is recommended.

QUESTION 01

This question was answered successfully by most students. Many were able to accurately define what is meant by the features of 'coding' and 'capacity'. Out of the two features, students were mostly successful when defining capacity in relation to the amount of information a store can hold. However, there were quite a number of students who demonstrated some confusion and/or inaccuracy in their definition of coding. It is important for students to understand that coding relates to how information is stored/held/processed into memory as many suggested coding is related just to the 'form/format' of memory.

QUESTION 02.1

This question produced some varied levels of responses. Many students were able to achieve either level 2 or 3 for this question by providing an accurate and detailed description of the working memory model. As expected, some students did show confusion between the two models of memory and described the multi-store model instead. Some responses lacked a clear and detailed explanation of each of the different components of the working memory model. Most students could name the four main parts and, in many cases, the sub-components of these parts. However, that was sometimes the extent of their answer. For 6 marks, there should have been detail of the functioning and/or interaction of the identified components.

QUESTION 02.2 and 02.3

Student's responses to both questions tended to follow a similar pattern. Many students were able to obtain 2 out of the 3 marks available; with a proportion gaining all 3 marks for each question. The main issue however was that, whilst many students could identify an accurate strength and/or limitation of the working memory model, few could take their points further by elaborating on this issue to provide more detail and clarification to make their evaluation point effective. Providing effective evaluation points is an area that students often struggle with and some need to explain why the strength or limitation they have chosen supports or exposes a weakness of the model..

QUESTION 03

Many students were able to achieve a level 2 response for this application question. It was nice to see how many students were able to take their understanding of cognitive interview and accurately apply it to the requirements of the question. Application questions seem to have been an area that teachers have been working on with their students and this was evident in the quality of many of the responses received.

QUESTION 04

It was a little surprising how few students were able to produce answers of a level 3 or 4 quality for this question. Considering the question should have been quite straight-forward for students to answer, it seemed as if many students did not understand the command word of 'discuss'. As a result, many students provided accurate and often detailed explanations of the different types of long-term memory; however, they did not then go on to provide any evaluation/discussion for this area. Consequently, this held many responses back to level 2. As with questions 2.2 and 2.3, when discussion was provided, it was often brief and ineffective with students simply stating vague strengths or limitations of a particular type of long-term memory, rather than expanding/explaining the discussion point in an effective way.

QUESTION 05

This question was a good discriminator as there was a range of responses across the available marks. Many students were able to provide an accurate and detailed description of social support as an explanation of resistance to social support. This often resulted in an answer that was worthy of a level 2 response. However, some students confused social support with locus of control and proceeded to explain this concept instead.

QUESTION 06.1

The majority of students were able to answer this question well and could accurately identify that Lucy demonstrated an external locus of control and Sarah had an internal locus of control. As expected, some students confused internal and external and consequently wrote their answers the wrong way round.

QUESTION 06.2

Despite most students getting full marks on question 6.1, a much lower number managed to obtain full marks for this question. Many were able to correctly identify that Sarah would be likely to resist, and could then provide a brief explanation of why Sarah would resist conformity. However, a significant number of students lost focus on the question. Instead of explaining why Sarah would be more likely to resist the pressure to conform (as requested in the question), they instead incorrectly focused on why Lucy would be more likely to conform. This was obviously not what the question asked and, consequently, they failed to access the second mark for their answer. Students must read the questions carefully and should check their answers against the questions when they have finished writing.

QUESTION 06.3

Only a small number of students were able to achieve a level 3 response for this question, with most obtaining level 1 or no marks at all. The main issue was, not reading the question properly. Many students treated this as a question requiring description but the question asked for an evaluation of locus of control. Students should know that they could be asked to evaluate an area of the specification without having to first describe it. Students must read the question carefully and identify the relevant command term(s) so that they do what the question specifically asks them to do.

QUESTION 07

This question provided a mixed level of responses. Many students could correctly identify the two situational variables present within this scenario (location and proximity). They were then able to write an accurate and detailed answer that applied those two variables to the scenario. Quite a number of students however focused on variables that were relevant to conformity rather than situational factors of obedience. Additionally, a number of students incorrectly focused on the term 'obey' within the question and wrote a lengthy and irrelevant explanation of Milgram's obedience study. Finally, some students attempted to take a hypothetical stance when trying to answer this question. Instead of focusing on the information that they had been given in the scenario, eg Jane is in a psychology lesson with her teacher; a number of students answered as if Jane was not in a lesson/in school and as if her teacher was not present and then explained why she would not obey. As with questions, 6.2 and 6.3, this is not what the question was asking for.

QUESTION 08

This question provided a similar range of responses to the previous extended response question, 04. Here, students needed to describe Asch's research into variables affecting conformity and most could do this successfully providing a clear summary of the different variables Asch studied including accurate results. However, some students provided lengthy and unnecessary descriptions of Asch's original study. Although this did receive some credit as his research into the different variables was based on the same set of procedures, it often resulted in students spending too long on their descriptions, which resulted in less time and/or focus on evaluation issues. Additionally, many students who provided lengthy descriptions of Asch's original study failed to focus on what the question wanted and, consequently, did not write about variations in his research.

In relation to the evaluation. Some students could provide accurate and detailed evaluation points. However, the majority of evaluation provided for this question was often either too brief, eg just stating that Asch's research lacked ecological validity, but not explaining how or why. Alternatively, some evaluation was more detailed but written in a generic way. For example, highlighting Asch's study was unethical as it broke ethical guidelines as participants were deceived. It is important that, when writing their evaluations, students must make every effort to link their writing specifically to the actual experiences in the situation. In this case, students could have explicitly highlight how Asch deceived his participants, eg they did not know the other participants were actually confederates and why this was necessary. This way the student's evaluations will become more effective and, consequently, gain higher marks

QUESTION 09

Most students did well on this question and could identify the two characteristics of phobias.

QUESTION 10

Most students obtained 1 mark on this question. However, only a small number gained both. Students needed to show that they understood that challenging irrational thoughts referred to a person confronting/testing thoughts (which most students identified) and then working to change/replace these with more suitable thinking. It was this second part that many students did not include within their responses.

QUESTION 11

Most students answered this question well and could provide a clear and accurate explanation of how Ellis's ABC model could be applied to Nish. Some students simply explained the ABC model and did not attempt to apply it to the scenario, whilst others just re-wrote the scenario. There was a number of students who were unable to apply all three stages of the model to Nish accurately.

QUESTION 12

This question provided a wide variety of responses. Some students produced answers that were deserving of level 3 and 4. These responses featured clear and accurate descriptions of both systematic desensitisation and flooding with relevant and effective evaluations of the therapies.

Most students were able to explain systematic desensitisation as a treatment of phobias. However, quite a number of these responses failed to include reference to the importance of relaxation at each stage of the anxiety hierarchy. This is a key principle of systematic desensitisation in which panic is replaced by a client becoming calm whilst being exposed to their phobic situation.

Whilst most students could describe systematic desensitisation well, the description of flooding as a therapy tended to be much poorer. These were usually limited to just the overall principle, eg immediate exposure to a fear object/situation. Not many students provided additional details, such as how flooding is based on the principle of extinction and how fear is a time-limited response.

Whilst some students gave effective evaluations for the treatments. Some raised questionable and often inaccurate 'evaluation issues,' such as highlighting how dangerous it would be for a person to leave flooding before the exposure event was finished, or the 'problem of untrained therapists carrying out treatment of phobias. These are rather spurious evaluations as psychological treatments are conducted by fully trained therapists and during flooding the safety of the client is paramount. There are many issues surrounding the use of these therapies without resorting to invented suggestion.

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